

The Euthyphro Dilemma and the Grounding of Morality

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Abstract

This paper examines the Euthyphro dilemma, originally formulated in Plato's *Euthyphro*, which questions whether moral rightness is grounded in divine commands or whether God commands certain actions because they are independently right (Plato, 1997). Simply put, the dilemma is the question: *Is an action good because God commands it or does God command it because it is good?* This dilemma has caused serious problems for the Divine Command Theory by raising concerns of arbitrariness on one hand and moral independence on the other. This paper focuses on Robert Adams' modified Divine Command Theory which grounds morality in God's necessarily loving nature (Adams, 1987). It evaluates whether this explanation avoids the two horns of the dilemma (arbitrariness and moral independence). The discussion also considers whether appeals to God's nature genuinely preserve the dependence of morality on the divine or whether they implicitly reintroduce an independent standard of goodness. The paper concludes that while Adams' approach offers a much more sophisticated theistic response to the dilemma than the simplified Divine Command Theory, it still faces pressure from versions of the Euthyphro dilemma in the form of the question: *Does grounding morality in God's nature truly explain moral truth or does it simply re-describe it?*

Introduction

In philosophy, one of the central questions in metaethics is how moral facts are grounded: what makes actions right or wrong and whether it depends on factors other than human judgement. In the philosophy of religion, this question becomes closely tied to theism as many thinkers have argued that God plays a foundational role in explaining moral value and moral obligation (Adams, 1987). If morality depends on God, then divine reality is often taken to provide an objective basis for ethics. If it does not, then morality must be explained independently of theism.

This issue is classically formulated in Plato's *Euthyphro*, where Socrates asks whether an action is morally right because the gods command it or if the gods command it because it is already morally right (Plato, 1997). This creates a dilemma for the Divine Command Theory and in fact for any divine command-based accounts of morality as if morality depends entirely on divine will, then it raises concerns of arbitrariness. On the other horn, if God command actions that are already morally right then morality seems to exist independently of God, which threatens the idea that God is the ultimate source of moral authority (Plato, 1997).

This paper evaluates this dilemma and its implications for the Divine Command Theory (DCT). It focuses primarily on Robert Adams' modified DCT, which grounds moral obligation not in arbitrary divine commands, but in the necessarily loving nature of God (Adams, 1987). It argues that while Adams' account significantly improves upon classical DCT by avoiding arbitrariness, it remains subject to other versions of the Euthyphro dilemma that raise concerns about whether grounding morality in God's nature truly explains moral truth or merely redefines it in theological terms.

Divine Command Theory

Divine Command Theory (DCT) is a metaethical view which holds that moral rightness and wrongness are grounded in the commands of God: what God commands is right and what God forbids is wrong (Adams, 1987). Moral obligation is therefore dependent on divine will and this makes God the ultimate source of moral authority.

One of the main attractions of DCT is that it provides an objective foundation for morality. By grounding moral values in God rather than human opinion or cultural convention, DCT aims to explain why moral obligations are universally binding and not merely subjective preferences. If moral values depend on God rather than individual opinion, cultural norms, or evolutionary development, then moral truths are not relative or subjective. For theists, this view also aligns naturally with the idea of God as the creator and ruler of the universe, whose authority extends to moral law as well as natural law.

Additionally, DCT offers a clear explanation of moral obligation. Moral duties are not seen as social agreements or evolutionary products, but as binding requirements by a perfectly authoritative being. This means that moral “oughts” are not optional or dependent on personal preference; they are categorical in nature. For defenders of DCT, this helps explain why moral obligations feel inescapable and universally applicable, since they are grounded in a source that transcends individual human perspectives. This gives morality a strong sense of necessity and seriousness since divine commands are understood to apply universally to all moral agents.

However, the theory faces an important philosophical challenge concerning the basis of moral value itself. If moral rightness is dependent on God’s commands, morality becomes arbitrary. If not, then it must be based on an independent standard

of goodness (Plato, 1997). This tension is classically formulated in the Euthyphro dilemma.

The Euthyphro Dilemma

The dilemma originates from *Euthyphro* and originally concerns piety, but the problem generalizes to morality as a whole (Plato, 1997) and has become a central challenge for DCT. The dilemma has two horns that need to be addressed.

The first horn states that if something is good simply because God commands it, then moral value depends entirely on divine will. On this view, there is no standard of goodness independent of God's commands. Whatever God commands is what is morally right solely because it has been commanded by God. Clearly, this position appears to secure a strong dependence of morality on God, but it raises serious concerns about arbitrariness. If God's commands alone determine what is good, then it seems logically possible that any action could have been morally required or forbidden (Plato, 1997). To understand this better, let's assume a hypothetical world where God commanded for the torture of children. If God commanding an action is all that makes it morally right, then in that hypothetical world, torturing children would become morally right. This threatens the idea that morality is necessarily objective or grounded in stable standards, since moral distinctions would depend entirely on divine choice rather than independent features of actions themselves.

The second horn takes the opposite direction. If God commands actions because they are already good, then moral standards must exist independently of God. On this view, goodness is a standard that precedes and constrains divine commands. God recognizes what is good and commands it accordingly but does not determine its goodness (Plato, 1997). However, this creates a problem for DCT, since it implies that

moral truths are not grounded in God at all. This undermines the claim that God is the ultimate source of moral authority, since morality would be metaphysically prior to God's commands rather than dependent on it. Hence, it makes God dependent on the independent standard of goodness that he must conform to.

Together, these two horns place DCT in a very difficult position. Either moral values are dependent on God's will, in which case they risk being arbitrary, or moral values are independent of God, in which case morality fails to be grounded in the divine. This tension motivates the need for more sophisticated accounts of the relationship between God and moral value that attempt to preserve both moral objectivity and divine authority.

In later philosophical discussions, this dilemma has often been expanded beyond its original context. While Plato's dialogue involves multiple gods in a Greek polytheistic setting, the structure of the argument does not depend on polytheism itself. The challenge remains even within monotheistic frameworks, since the issue is not disagreement between gods, but the logical relation between divine will and moral truth (Plato, 1997). For this reason, the Euthyphro dilemma has become a standard objection to DCT in contemporary philosophy of religion.

Modern Response: Robert Adams

Robert Adams develops a modified version of DCT in response to the Euthyphro dilemma (Adams, 1987). Unlike simple DCT which identifies moral rightness as a result of God's commands, Adams rejects the idea that moral terms are merely equivalent in meaning to divine commands. Instead, he proposes that DCT should be understood as a theory of moral truth-making rather than a semantic

definition. On this view, moral claims are not defined by God's commands but are made true or false in virtue of facts about God's nature and will (Adams, 1987).

A central feature of Adams' account is the claim that moral obligation is grounded in the nature of a perfectly good and all-loving God. God is not conceived as arbitrarily choosing moral rules, but as essentially good in a necessary way. This means that God's commands are not independent acts of will that could have been otherwise without constraint. Rather, they flow from God's essential moral character. Because God is necessarily loving, just, and good, the content of divine commands is constrained in this nature. This is not to say that God is restrained by his good nature, but it means that God could not have commanded anything else because that is not what God is like – that simply is not who he is. In this way, Adams attempts to preserve the dependence of morality on God while avoiding the arbitrariness problem raised by the first horn of the Euthyphro dilemma.

On this account, moral truths are not external standards that God consults when issuing commands. Instead, they are grounded in God's own nature, which functions as the ultimate source of moral value. This view allows Adams to argue that morality is neither independent of God nor subject to arbitrary divine choice. Moral goodness is not something external to God but is identified with or derived from God's essential character. In this sense, God does not "decide" what is good in a discretionary way; rather, what is good is necessarily connected to what God is.

Adams also makes an important distinction between the meaning of moral language and its metaphysical grounding. He argues that DCT should not be interpreted as a theory about the definitions of moral terms. Instead, it is a theory about what makes moral statements true. This distinction is crucial because it allows him to avoid the objection of circularity that often arises in simple formulations of

DCT. If one were to define “good” as “commanded by God”, then moral arguments involving God would be trivially circular. However, if DCT is understood as a metaphysical thesis about moral truth-makers, then it is possible to argue that God grounds morality without defining moral terms in theological language.

This shift also allows Adams to respond to a common objection that we must already understand morality in order to understand God’s nature as good. Critics argue that saying “God is good” appears to presuppose an independent standard of goodness, which would imply that morality is prior to God. Adams’ response is to distinguish between epistemology and metaphysics. Epistemologically, we may come to know moral truths independently and then use them to reason about God. However, metaphysically, these moral truths are still grounded in God’s nature. To understand this better, let’s consider a thermometer: we use a thermometer to measure temperature, but the thermometer does not create temperature itself. Similarly, our moral judgements may give us access to moral truths, while God’s nature remains the ultimate ground of those truths.

Despite these strengths, Adams’ view faces several important philosophical pressures. One concern is whether appealing to God’s loving nature genuinely explains moral truth or merely restates it in theological terms. If “good” is defined as “God’s nature”, then the statement “God is good” becomes “God is what God is”, which is tautological. If we define God as “perfectly good”, there is a risk that we are simply embedding moral standards into the definition of God, rather than explaining their origin. This raises the worry that the account may be circular at a deeper explanatory level, even if it avoids formal definitional circularity (Adams, 1987).

Another challenge concerns the explanatory role of divine nature itself. It is unclear whether saying that morality is grounded in God’s nature provides a genuine

explanation of why certain actions are right or wrong or whether it simply relocates the question. For example, stating that cruelty is wrong because it contradicts God's loving nature may still leave open the question of why God's nature should be considered the standard of goodness in the first place. In this sense, the explanatory pressure of the Euthyphro dilemma may reappear at the level of divine nature rather than divine command. Theists may argue that scripture says that God is good, hence God is good and must be used as the standard of goodness, but it is important to note that while that claim is valid as a doctrinal observation and is a descriptive claim about religious belief, it does not address the philosophical concern that the concept of goodness may still be doing explanatory work independently of divine nature.

A further issue concerns the relationship between moral knowledge and divine grounding. Even if moral truths are metaphysically grounded in God, it remains the case that we appear to access moral truths through independent moral reasoning and intuition (Adams, 1987). In ordinary moral reasoning, we do not typically infer that an action is right or wrong by first appealing to God and then deriving moral conclusions. Instead, we appear to rely on moral intuition, reflection, and rational evaluation of cases. For example, we may judge that cruelty is wrong directly without any explicit reference to divine commands or divine nature. This raises a tension between epistemic independence and metaphysical dependence. While Adams' distinction between these domains is useful, critics may argue that it is not fully satisfying if it leaves unclear how divine grounding contributes to our actual understanding of moral truth.

A possible theistic response is that God, as the ground of morality, has also given human beings an innate capacity to recognize moral truths through conscience or rational moral intuition. On this view, epistemic independence is not a threat to

divine grounding, since it is precisely what one would expect if God intended humans to reliably track moral truth without constant explicit reference to him. However, critics may argue that this response still leaves open the question of why such intuitions should be considered reliable indicators of God-grounded moral facts, thereby introducing the problem at the level of justification.

Finally, Adams' argument does not necessarily establish a full monotheistic or doctrinally specific conclusion. At most, it supports the existence of a necessarily good being whose nature grounds moral value. It does not by itself entail attributes such as omnipotence or the full structure of classical theism. As a result, while Adams' view significantly refines DCT and avoids the most direct version of the Euthyphro dilemma, it remains open to further philosophical pressure regarding explanation and grounding.

Critical Evaluation

The Euthyphro dilemma remains of the most significant challenges for any attempt to ground morality in God (Plato, 1997). It forces a choice between two seemingly unsatisfactory alternatives: either moral truths depend entirely on divine commands, which threatens arbitrariness, or moral truths exist independently of God, which undermines the claim that God is the ultimate source of morality. DCT in its simplest form struggles to avoid both horns simultaneously, which motivates more sophisticated accounts such as Robert Adams' modified DCT (Adams, 1987). The central question, therefore, is whether Adams successfully avoids the dilemma or merely relocates its difficulties.

Adams' main strength lies in rejecting the idea that DCT should be understood as a semantic definition of moral terms. By treating it instead as a theory of moral

truth-making, he avoids the immediate circularity that arises when “good” is defined as “commanded by God.” This allows him to maintain that moral statements retain their ordinary meaning while still being grounded in divine reality. This distinction between meaning and grounding is philosophically important because it prevents the theory from collapsing into triviality. It also allows Adams to argue that moral reasoning can proceed without explicit reference to God, since epistemology and metaphysics are separated.

However, while this move is conceptually useful, it does not fully resolve the deeper explanatory concerns raised by the Euthyphro dilemma. Adams’ appeal to God’s essentially loving nature is intended to avoid arbitrariness by constraining divine commands. Because God is necessarily good, his commands cannot be arbitrary in the way that the first horn of the dilemma suggests. Yet this response introduces a further question: what exactly does it mean to say that God’s nature is “good”, and does this genuinely explain moral value or merely restate it in theological form? If moral goodness is fully identified with God’s nature, then the claim that “God is good” risks becoming tautological. On this reading, instead of explaining why certain actions are right or wrong, the theory may simply redefine goodness as whatever is associated with divine perfection.

This concern leads to a deeper version of the explanatory problem. Even if one accepts that moral truths are grounded in God’s nature, it remains unclear whether this grounding provides a substantial explanation of moral properties. Saying that cruelty is wrong because it contradicts God’s loving nature may appear to explain wrongdoing, but it may also simply shift the question: why should God’s nature be considered the standard of goodness in the first place? In this sense, the Euthyphro-style pressure reappears not at the level of divine commands, but at the level of divine

nature itself. The theory avoids arbitrariness at one level only to face potential explanatory circularity at another.

A response available to defenders of modified DCT is to argue that God's commands track what is beneficial for human beings not because such acts are independently good, but because God's perfect knowledge of all relevant facts about human flourishing determines what is appropriate to command. On this view, divine omniscience ensures that moral requirements are not arbitrary, since God's commands reflect a complete understanding of the consequences of actions. However, critics may argue that this merely shifts the explanatory burden, since it remains unclear why human benefit itself should constitute moral goodness unless it is already assumed within the theory.

A further challenge concerns the relationship between metaphysical grounding and moral knowledge. Even if moral truths are grounded in God's nature, it is not obvious how this grounding plays a role in our actual moral understanding. In practice, people appear to access moral truths through intuition, reflection, and rational evidence of cases rather than through explicit reasoning about God. This creates tension between metaphysical dependence and epistemic independence. A possible theistic response is that God has designed humans with an innate moral capacity - such as conscience or rational intuition - that allows them to recognize moral truths directly. On this view, epistemic independence is not a problem but an expected feature of divine design.

However, this response does not fully remove the philosophical concern. Even if God has implanted moral awareness in human beings, it remains unclear why such intuitions should be regarded as reliable indicators of objective moral truth. The justification for their reliability seems to require either independent moral reasoning

or some further argument linking them to divine nature. Without this, the account risks leaving an explanatory gap between metaphysical grounding and justified moral knowledge.

It may seem like any and all possible explanations will be met with another “why” and this is an excellent observation. As a result, defenders can also argue that every moral theory must terminate in some fundamental explanatory principle. If secular moral realism ultimately appeals to brute or necessary moral facts, then appealing to God’s necessary nature may not be uniquely problematic. Moreover, the argument could be made that grounding and knowing should not have to coincide. For example, gravity is grounded in the laws of physics, but you do not need to know physics to know that dropping a glass will make it fall.

Another limitation of Adams’ approach is that it does not decisively resolve the broader explanatory ambitions of the Euthyphro dilemma. While it offers a more refined account than DCT, it may still struggle to show that God is doing substantive explanatory work in grounding morality. If moral truths can be accessed and reasoned about independently and if God’s role is primarily to metaphysically ground what is already known, then the theory risks making God’s contribution appear conceptually remote from actual moral practice. This does not refute the view, but it weakens its explanatory immediacy.

At the same time, it is important to recognize the strength of Adams’ position relative to simpler alternatives. Unlike straightforward DCT, his view preserves moral stability by anchoring goodness in the necessarily loving nature of God rather than in arbitrary divine choice. This gives the theory an intuitive advantage in avoiding the most severe form of arbitrariness. It also preserves a strong connection between

morality and theism, allowing moral facts to be understood as dependent on a perfect being rather than independent abstract entities.

Overall, Adams' account significantly weakens the force of the Euthyphro dilemma but does not eliminate it entirely. It succeeds in avoiding the most direct form of arbitrariness and provides a sophisticated alternative to simple DCT. However, questions remain about whether grounding morality in divine nature provides a genuine explanation of moral truth or whether it merely restates moral concepts in theological terms. Additionally, the relationship between metaphysical grounding and epistemic access remains partially unresolved. The result is a position that is philosophically plausible and internally coherent, but still subject to ongoing pressure regarding explanation, justification, and the ultimate role of God in moral theory.

Conclusion

The Euthyphro dilemma remains one of the most influential challenges to theistic accounts of morality because it forces a confrontation with two fundamental concerns: arbitrariness and independence (Plato, 1997). If moral truths depend solely on divine commands, morality appears vulnerable to arbitrariness. If God commands actions because they are already good, morality seems to exist independently of God. This tension has made the dilemma a central topic in discussion of moral grounding.

While simple versions of DCT struggle to respond to both horns of the dilemma, contemporary approaches such as Robert Adams' modified DCT offer a more sophisticated alternative. By grounding morality in the nature of a necessarily loving God rather than in arbitrary acts of will, Adams attempts to preserve both divine sovereignty and objective moral truth (Adams, 1987). This approach

successfully addresses some of the strongest criticisms directed at traditional DCT and demonstrates that the dilemma is not as decisive as it is often presented.

Nevertheless, important philosophical questions remain. In particular, it is not clear whether grounding morality in God's nature provides a genuine explanation of moral value or simply relocates the explanatory challenge. The debate therefore shifts from divine commands to the status and explanatory role of divine nature itself. As a result, the Euthyphro dilemma is best understood not as a definitive refutation of theistic ethics, but as an enduring challenge that continues to shape contemporary discussions about the foundations of morality. Ultimately, the question of whether morality is grounded in God or in some independent moral reality remains one of the most significant and contested issues in the philosophy of religion.

References

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